

TMU Graduate Research-A-Thon

A proposal to incubate research, build community, and accelerate funding.

Proposed by the TMU Computer Science Graduate Student Union (CSGSU)
for the Yeates School of Graduate and Postdoctoral Studies (YSGPS).

Representatives:

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A New Model for Graduate Innovation

A fully online, two-week event where STEM graduate students collaborate to turn “wild ideas” into concise, fundable research proposals. Unlike a traditional hackathon, there is no code to write and no overnight sprints. The output is academic rigour, not a demo.

Key Value Propositions:

- **Inclusive:** Fully virtual format supports caregivers, commuters, and those with mobility constraints.
- **Interdisciplinary:** Breaks down silos between labs and departments.
- **Educational:** Teaches grant writing, peer review, and responsible AI usage.
- **Flexible:** Can be run on a 'flagship' budget or a 'zero-cost' model.

Target: All STEM graduate students at TMU.



The Gap in Graduate Training

Current State: The Silo



Graduate training is often isolating. Labs operate in parallel. Students lack “safe” spaces to test unconventional hypotheses without reputational risk. Cross-pollination is rare.

Future State: The Network



A structured, low-friction forum for interdisciplinary collision. Students learn to articulate problems, not just solve them. The Research-A-Thon provides scaffolding—team formation, problem prompts, and mentorship.

“The goal is not merely to generate ideas quickly, but to produce better ideas—supported by community and disciplined by scrutiny.”

Strategic Alignment with YSGPS Mandates

1. Student Experience & Well-being

Combats isolation through social mechanisms (speed networking, themed problem rooms) and psychological safety.

2. Equity, Diversity & Inclusion

Online-first design with humane hours, captioning, and low-bandwidth modes ensures no discipline or participation mode is disadvantaged.

Toronto
Metropolitan
University

3. Academic Excellence

Participants produce rigorous artifacts: a ≤ 3 -page proposal and a 3-minute pitch, evaluated on significance and feasibility.

4. Funding Success

Accelerates student success in external grants by producing a backlog of vetted, submission-ready mini-proposals.

Reimagining the Hackathon for Research

	Classic Hackathon	Graduate Research-A-Thon
Duration	24-48 Hours (Overnight marathons)	2 Weeks (Humane pacing, time for deep thought)
Output	Flashy Prototype / Code	Fundable Proposal (PDF) + Pitch
Focus	Execution & Spectacle	Theory, Methodology, & Feasibility
Bias	Privileges Coders / CS	Discipline-Neutral (Theory, Wet-lab, Sim)
Deliverable	Demo	Abstract, Gap, Method, Impact, & LLM Statement

The Participant Journey: From Spark to Submission



Phase 1: Pre-Event (The Setup)

Discord opens for
Interest Channels (e.g.,
Linguistics, Bio-Sim).
Team forming mixers.



Phase 2: Week 1 (Ideation)

Day 1: Opening
Ceremony (Zoom)
Activities: Workshops,
'Open-Mic', Icebreakers
Support: Mentor Consults
(15-min slots).



Phase 3: Week 2 (Refinement)

Drafting the ≤ 3 -page
proposal. Pitch practice.
Submission Deadline:
Day 14 at 11:59 PM.



Phase 4: Assessment

Peer Review (48 hours).
Closing Ceremony &
Awards.

Technical Stack & Accessibility

Discord



The persistent community hub. Team voice rooms, help desk, announcements.

Zoom

Plenaries, Opening/Closing ceremonies. Features: Waiting rooms, authenticated links, screen-share controls.

Google Drive

Repository for rules, templates, and submission forms.

Accessibility & Inclusion Standards

Low-Bandwidth Mode: Helvetica Now Display

Georgia Pro
Explicit norms for camera-off participation and dial-in audio; PDF slide backups required.

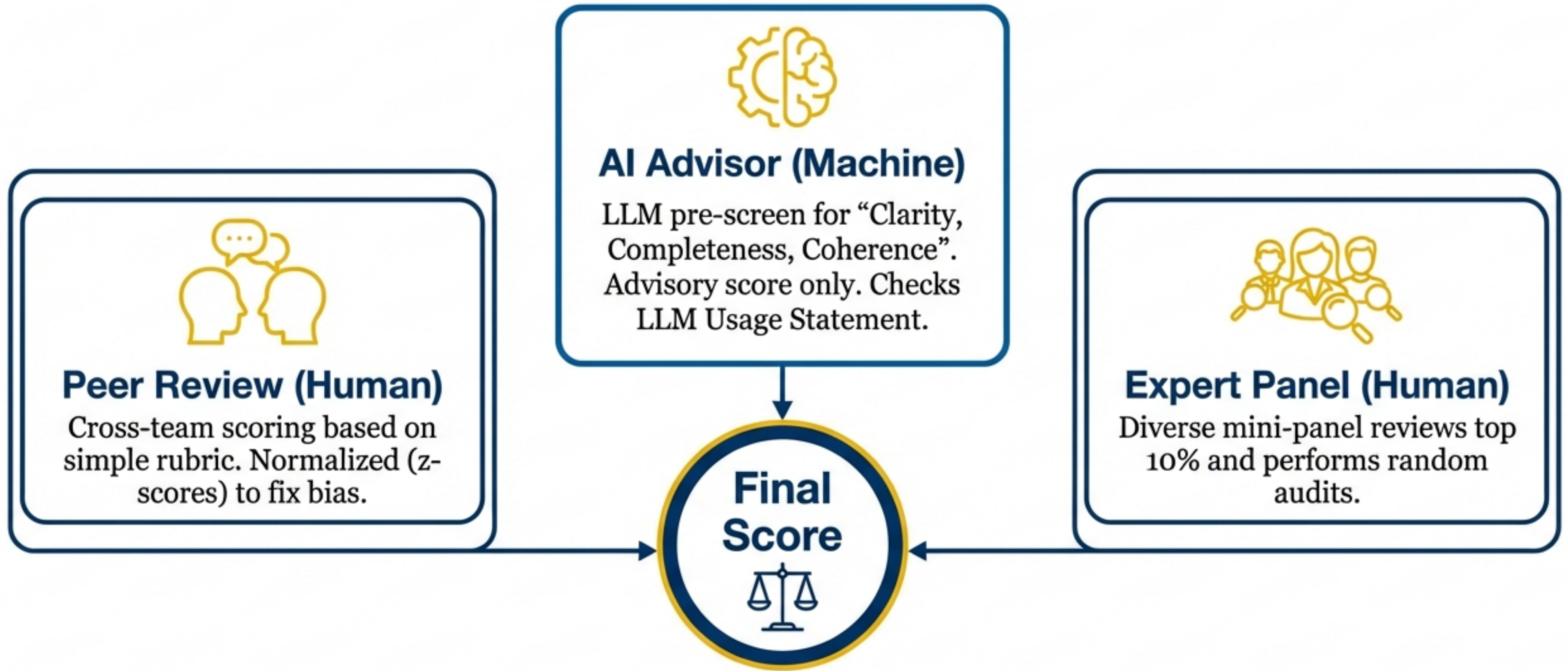
Captions: Helvetica Now Display

Georgia Pro
Auto-captioning on all plenaries; recordings posted immediately.

Time Zones: Helvetica Now Display

Georgia Pro
Schedule anchors in America/Toronto but lists UTC; explicit 30+ min breaks.

Innovative Evaluation: Triangulated Judging



Rubric: Novelty (25%) | Significance (20%) | Feasibility (20%) | Clarity (20%) | Field Merit (15%)

Governance & Leadership Roles



Roles can be handled by any STEM grad student; minimum team of 5.

Proactive Risk Management

Risk Scenario	Planned Mitigation
Tech Failure	Pivot to Google Meet backup links; “Low-bandwidth” documentation ready.
AI Misuse/Plagiarism	Mandatory ‘LLM Usage Statement’; Rubric weights scientific judgment over surface polish.
Exclusion	Asynchronous options & Accessibility Lead; Camera-off norms.
Fairness	Anonymized PDFs; Conflict-of-interest checks; Score normalization.
Privacy	Teams retain IP. Data collection minimized.

Continuous monitoring throughout the event lifecycle.

Timeline: T-4 to T+3 Months



Flexible Financial Support Models

Meaningful incentives increase participation. The event functions on any budget.

Scenario A: Funded (Preferred)

- Research Catalyst Awards: Seed grants (\$3k / \$1k / \$500) deposited to research accounts.
- Sponsorships: Departmental “Challenge Tracks” (\$500-\$1000).

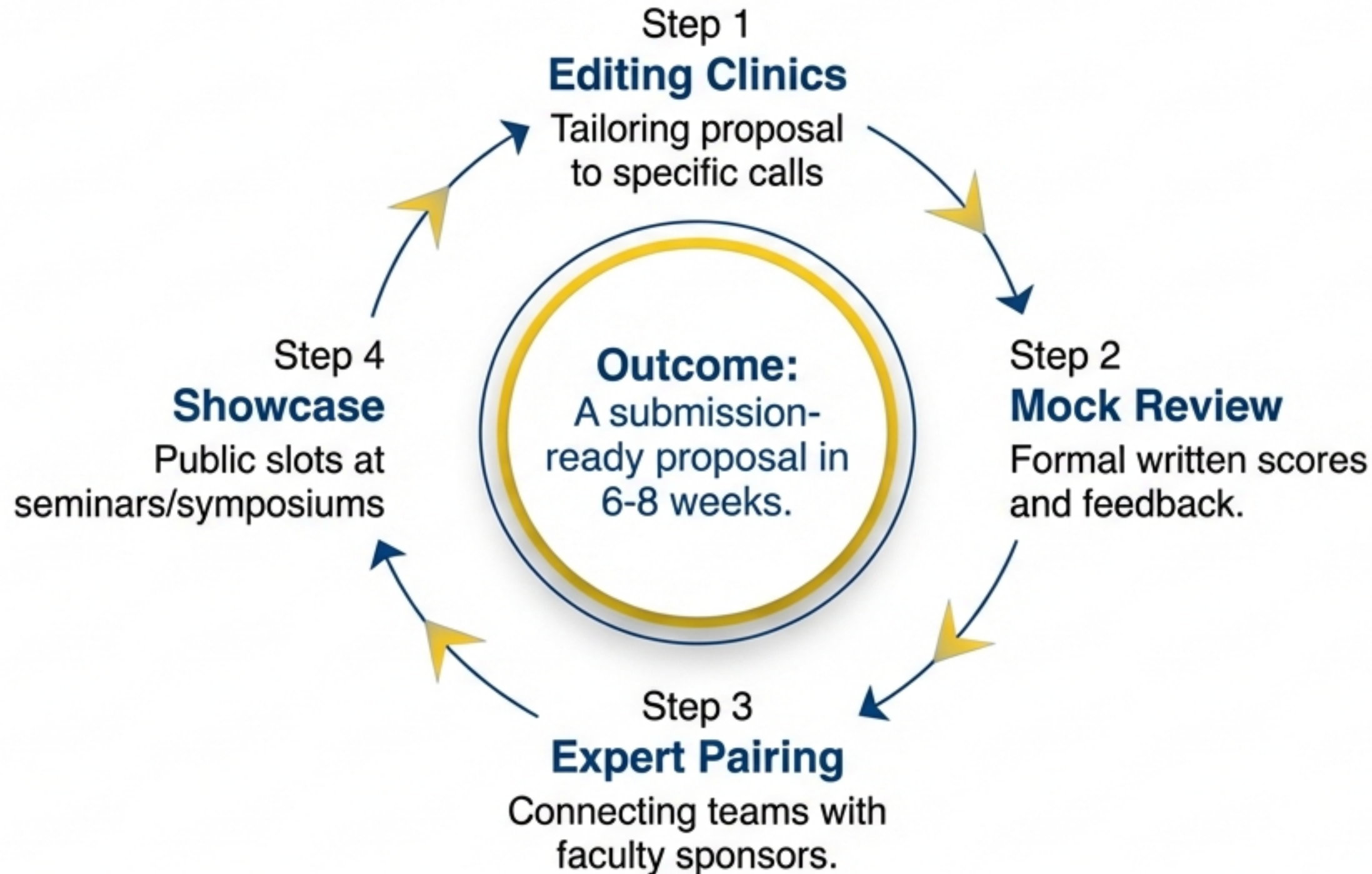
Scenario B: Zero Budget (Feasible)

- Career Catalyst Prizes: Guaranteed interviews, Internships, Incubator admissions.
- Value Driver: The “Grant Acceleration Package” (Editing clinics, Mock reviews).

Operational costs (venue/catering) are zero due to online format.

The Grant Acceleration Package

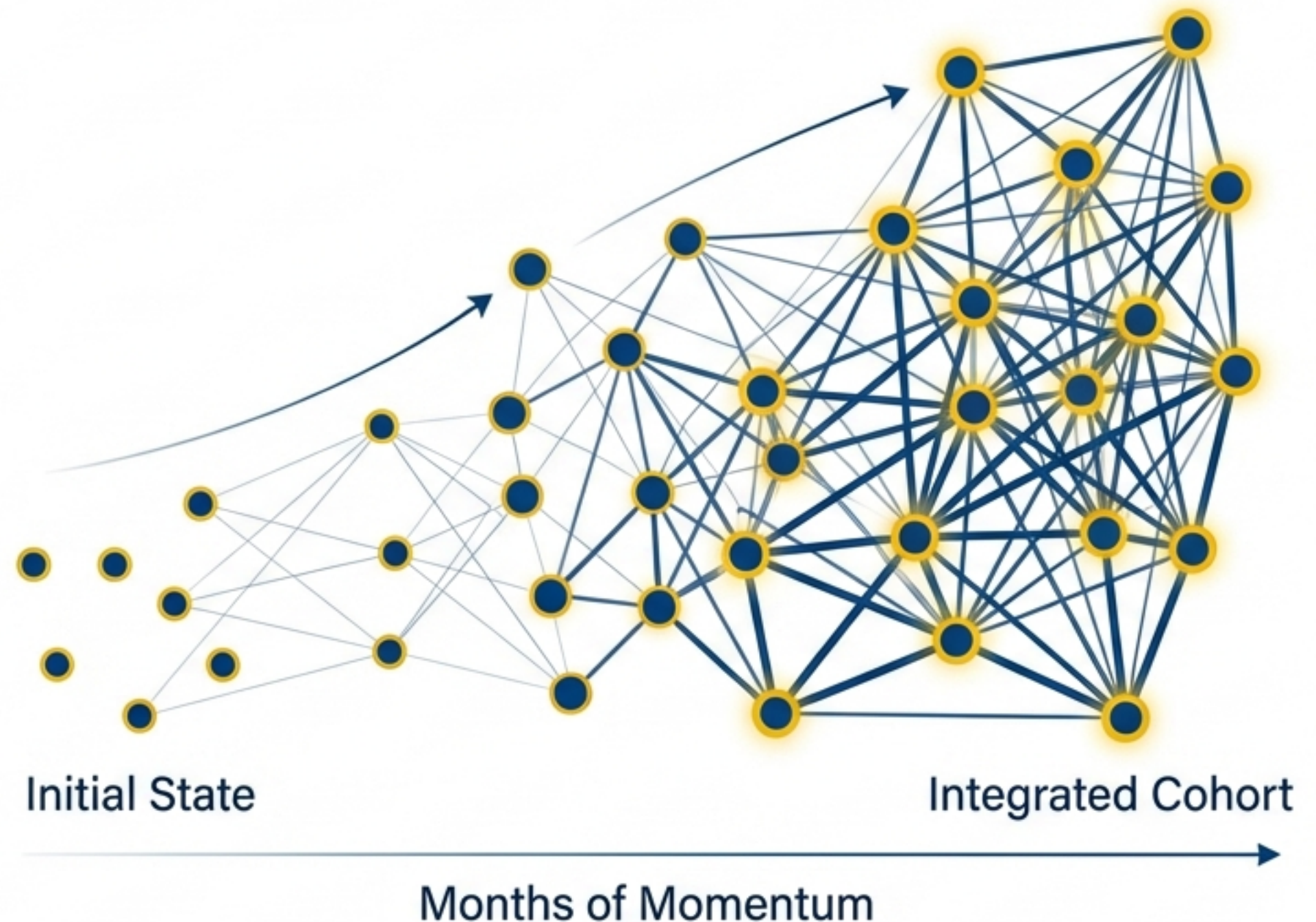
Creating value without cash prizes.



Legacy & Continuity

Post-Event Pathways

- **Momentum:** Discord stays open as a persistent community hub.
- **Timeline:**
 - **T+1 Month:** Feedback delivered to all teams.
 - **T+2 Months:** Convert proposals to pilots.
 - **T+3 Months:** Close loop for next year.
- **Impact:** Creating a backlog of vetted proposals and a connected cohort.



Conclusion & The Ask

A **high-impact**, low-overhead initiative that drives **Research, Community, and Career Readiness. Scalable, inclusive**, and **aligned** with YSGPS mandates.

Action Required:

1. Approve the Concept.
2. Select Funding Tier (Cash vs. Service).
3. Authorize Date Hold.

“Turning two weeks of focus into months of momentum.”